



Red Brigade, Lucknow - A Brief Introduction

Red Brigade is a girls/young women survivors-led organization, aiming towards building a safe society and ensuring a zero-tolerance atmosphere towards sexual violence. It was founded in 2011 by Ms. Usha Vishwakarma, who herself is a survivor, with the support of 15 adolescent girls. Most of them are also survivors of sexual violence belonging to marginalized communities like Dalits, Muslims and Other backward Communities. The organization further aims towards ensuring the participation of adolescent girls and young women from the marginalized communities who themselves are survivors of sexual violence. The idea of building up this kind of leadership also helps in penetration of the idea of recreating self-defense and self-image into the society.

Red Brigade is a journey of Usha, who is fighting against sexual violence and transforming into an organization. This began in small Basti in Madiyaon located in Lucknow. Over the decade, Red Brigade has become a pioneer in fight against Sexual violence inflicted upon adolescent girls and young women. It has given them the courage to raise a powerful collective voice and fight against sexual violence and strengthened them to have a virtue to fight against patriarchal mindset. In this process of traversing of victim to survivors by hammering the evil masculinity, Red Brigade has transformed the lives of a lot of girls. It has helped hundreds of survivors' access justice. Red Brigade has trained around 200000 1 lakh adolescent girls/young in this preventive skill against sexual violence by re-inventing self- defense (NISHASTRA). Not only they have developed a belief in protection but this process also inspired them to re-discover their self-image. Red Brigade has been known across the world for its long and impact-full struggle towards ensuring a society free from Sexual Violence.

The base location of Red Brigade is in Lucknow but it has outreach in 450 villages, 500 schools in 13 states and 75 districts Within Lucknow itself, Red Brigade has intervened across 150 villages and 250 schools. Our initiatives have been noticed by about sixty countries 2, and the organization has been the subject of several national and international

Media stories and documentaries. Red Brigade has received dozens of awards 3 including from the Government of India, Uttar Pradesh Government, and Forbes India Magazine 2020 India's Top 20 Women Achievers. Many academic institutions have published some research and books on Red Brigade.

Vision

To establish and create a 'FLOW' (Fearless Life of Women).

Mission

- **Combat sexual violence** through self-defense training using the skill-based technique called 'Nishastra'.
- **Provide psychological** and mental health support, socio-legal assistance, shelter, and rehabilitation to create an empathetic environment for survivors.
- **Promote gender sensitization** and awareness to break the silence around sexual violence and gender discrimination, encouraging women to raise powerful voices against it.
- **Build a platform against sexual violence** by collaborating with NGOs, civil society organizations, media, government agencies, legal allies, and police.
- **Foster leadership** and community building through workshops, self-defense training programs, and awareness initiatives, primarily targeting young women and girls (adults and adolescents).
- **Support educational empowerment** by providing material and emotional support for girls from socio-economically marginalized communities to continue education beyond the primary level.
- **Promote economic self-reliance** by offering skill-based training to strengthen the financial independence of young women and girls.

Red Brigade's Journey in Combating Sexual Violence

- Conducted training programs in approximately 150 districts across 13 states in India, with a primary focus on Lucknow. Trained over 200,000 young women, girls, and adolescents in self-defense using the 'Nishastr' technique.
- Prepared 100 self-defense master trainers and trainers from 40 districts, including Lucknow, in Uttar Pradesh, with over 1,000 active volunteers.
- Active in 225 educational institutions (schools, professional and technical institutes, universities) and 200 villages in Lucknow, working with adolescent girls and young women from marginalized communities in government and low-cost schools.

- Organized training workshops for safe workplaces, targeting women police, local institution representatives, doctors, paramedics, women helpline workers, and female teachers.
- Conducted training workshops for numerous corporate companies.

Key Programs

- 100 Days, 100 Schools (2017): Trained 23,000 girls, supported by Times of India and Radio Mirchi.
- War against 936 (2019-2020): Trained 4,000 girls.
- Mission Shakti and Kavach Mission (2019-2020): Trained 57,000 young women and girls under Uttar Pradesh government initiatives.
- Sashakt Kishori (2022-24): Trained 20,000 adolescent girls.
- 100 Days, 100 Villages (2020-21): Trained approximately 5,000 girls.

Response to Violence

- Formed dedicated teams to address rape and sexual violence: response team, legal advisory team, and rehabilitation and counseling team, comprising medical practitioners, judicial officers (including from the transgender community), prominent women, social activists, radio jockeys, and media personnel.
- Successfully rehabilitated 5 rape survivors and assisted in their legal proceedings. Worked with over 200 survivors of sexual violence, domestic abuse, and harassment, providing medical, legal, and psychological support.

Gender Sensitization and Awareness

- Spread awareness against sexual violence and harassment through approximately 700 street plays (nukkad natak) in streets, schools, colleges, offices, metro, and railway stations over the past decade.
- Organized the 14-day activism program 'Raat ka Ujala' annually from December 16 to 29 in memory of Nirbhaya (victim of the 2012 Delhi gang rape), aiming to challenge patriarchal systems and regressive mindsets. Events include 'Ek Chai Mahila Samman Mein' (2018) and a 936-foot banner human chain (2019).
- Played a significant role in reviving National Women's Day celebrations (February 13, Sarojini Naidu's birth anniversary). Initiated an 18-day activism campaign in 2018, including the 'Prerna Yatra' (vehicle rally) covering 50 districts across four states. Other events include 'Salute to Sarojini' (2019) with 140 events across Lucknow and a 'One Million Meter March' scooter rally in 100 villages (2021). In 2023, 50 girls marched from Bhojla, Jhansi, to Lucknow. These efforts have led to National Women's Day events in approximately 150 districts.
- Launched 'Veerangana Vahini' in 2025, with 1,000 young women and girls from 40 districts in Uttar Pradesh participating.
- Conducted the 12-day 'Hinsa Mukht Jeevan' activism campaign (2022) from September 21 (International Peace Day) to October 2 (Gandhi Jayanti), engaging 100 volunteers and reaching 10,000 girls with self-defense training.

Leadership and Community Building

- Organized a 14-day march in 2016 with participation from women lawyers, doctors, nurses, media personalities, government officials, and women's organization leaders.
- Conducted programs in 100 Lucknow schools in 2017, facilitating dialogues between girls and 100 women leaders.
- Recognized emerging women leaders in fields like traffic police, women police, petrol pump workers, security guards, and e-rickshaw drivers through 'Raat ka Ujala'.

- Organized 'Ladki Nidar, Kare Vote ki Fikr' (2023-24), raising voting awareness among girls in 75 educational institutions and 25 villages, with 75 women leaders reaching 10,000 girls, including self-defense workshops.
- Conducted approximately 300 workshops on gender sensitization and awareness in educational institutions and communities.
- Identified and encouraged girls and women, especially survivors, as community leaders through self-defense and other workshops.

Educational Empowerment and Support

- Operated 'Bal Manch,' an educational center for nearly a decade, serving children from marginalized communities.
- Provided free bridge courses to mainstream children into education and financial support for girls to continue education beyond the primary level, benefiting over 1,000 children.
- Supported approximately 200 girls from marginalized communities with financial aid for further education.

Economic Upliftment

- Runs 'Apna Hunar Training Centre,' offering skill-based training in tailoring, beauty parlor courses, mehndi design, culinary arts, and 'Marma Chikitsa' (traditional health knowledge system).
- Trained over 350 young women and girls in these skills.

COVID-19 Crisis Intervention

- Provided ration kits and daily essentials to 20,000 people (4,000 families) during the first wave (March-July 2020) and 15,000 people (3,000 families) during the second wave (April-September 2021).
- Distributed 25,000 cooked meal packets in the first wave and 7,000 in the second wave.

- Provided 18,000 milk and oatmeal packets and 1,500 nutrition and immunity kits to children during the first wave.
- Prioritized women's participation by ensuring relief items were delivered through women in beneficiary families.
- Counseled women facing a surge in domestic violence during the lockdown.

Recognitions and Awards

- Noticed by over 50 countries, featured in documentaries and widely covered in print media.
- Forbes India Magazine Self-Made Woman 2020: Top 20 Women Achievers in India.
- Rani Laxmibai Award (Uttar Pradesh Government).
- '100 Women Achievers of India' (by the President of India) and several other prestigious awards.
- Invited as special guests on popular TV shows like Stree Shakti (Doordarshan), Kaun Banega Crorepati (Sony), No More Kamzor (Star Plus), Savdhaan India (Life OK), Live Zindagi (Network 18), and others.

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